

Deep Learning for Efficient Image Restoration: A Comparative Study of Lightweight U-Net Architectures

Final Project Group 3

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Abstract

This report presents the development and evaluation of a deep learning-based image restoration system designed for resource-constrained environments. While state-of-the-art models like Restoration Transformers achieve high fidelity, their computational cost prohibits deployment on edge devices. We address this by implementing a **Lightweight U-Net** architecture utilizing **Depthwise Separable Convolutions**. Our experiments demonstrate that this architecture achieves a **21.98 dB PSNR** on the COCO dataset, matching the visual quality of a standard U-Net while reducing model parameters by **8.6x** and computational cost (FLOPs) by **7.0x**. Finally, we demonstrate the practical utility of the model through a deployed Streamlit web application capable of real-time denoising.

1 Introduction

Image restoration, specifically denoising, is a fundamental problem in computer vision aimed at recovering a clean image x from a corrupted observation $y = x + n$, where n represents noise. Traditional methods relied on hand-crafted filters (e.g., BM3D), but recent advancements have shifted towards learning-based approaches using Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs).

The **U-Net** architecture, originally proposed for biomedical segmentation by Ronneberger et al. [1], has become a standard baseline for restoration due to its ability to preserve spatial details via skip connections. However, standard U-Nets are computationally expensive. This project investigates whether modern efficient convolution techniques, specifically those introduced in **MobileNets** [2], can be integrated into a U-Net to drastically reduce its size without sacrificing restoration quality.

2 Methodology

2.1 Data Pipeline and Augmentation

We utilized the **COCO 2017 Unlabeled Dataset** [3], comprising approximately 123,000 diverse real-world images. To ensure robust training without labels, we implemented a self-supervised pipeline:

- **Input:** Synthetic corruption was applied on-the-fly using a custom `add_noise` function.
- **Noise Types:** Random selection between Gaussian Noise ($\sigma = 0.5$) and Salt-and-Pepper Noise.
- **Augmentation:** To prevent overfitting and encourage invariance, we applied `RandomHorizontalFlip` and `RandomCrop` (256×256) during training.

2.2 Model Architecture: The Lightweight U-Net

Our primary contribution is the implementation of a **Lightweight U-Net** that replaces standard convolutional blocks with **Depthwise Separable Convolutions (DSConv)**.

- **Standard Convolution:** Performs spatial filtering and channel mixing simultaneously. Computational cost: $D_K^2 \cdot M \cdot N \cdot D_F^2$.
- **Depthwise Separable Convolution:** Decomposes the operation into:
 1. *Depthwise Conv:* Filters each channel independently.
 2. *Pointwise Conv:* Mixes channels using a 1×1 kernel.

This factorization reduces computation by a factor of $\frac{1}{N} + \frac{1}{D_K^2}$ [2].

My architecture follows a 4-level encoder-decoder structure with skip connections, using DSConvDouble blocks at each stage to capture complex features efficiently.

2.3 Loss Function

To address the "blurriness" associated with Mean Squared Error (MSE) loss, we implemented a **Combined Loss Function** leveraging structural similarity:

$$\mathcal{L}_{total} = \alpha \cdot (1 - \text{SSIM}(x, \hat{x})) + (1 - \alpha) \cdot \|x - \hat{x}\|_1 \quad (1)$$

where SSIM is the Structural Similarity Index [4] and L_1 is the Mean Absolute Error. This combination prioritizes both pixel-level accuracy and perceptual structure.

3 Experiments and Results

3.1 Experimental Setup

- **Hardware:** NVIDIA A10G GPU (AWS EC2).
- **Training Config:** Batch Size = 32, Adam Optimizer ($lr = 0.001$), 50 Epochs.
- **Baselines:**
 - **Simple Autoencoder:** A shallow 3-layer CNN without skip connections.
 - **Standard Heavy U-Net:** An equivalent U-Net using standard convolutions.

3.2 Quantitative Results

We evaluated model efficiency and performance using Parameter Count, FLOPs, and Peak Signal-to-Noise Ratio (PSNR).

Table 1: Comparison of Model Efficiency and Computational Cost

Model Architecture	Parameters	FLOPs (per 256px)	Reduction Factor
Standard Heavy U-Net	7,852,611	14.10 GFLOPs	1.0x (Baseline)
Lightweight U-Net	915,587	2.03 GFLOPs	~8.6x Smaller

Performance Metrics:

The Lightweight U-Net achieved an **8.6x reduction in size** and **7.0x reduction in computational cost** compared to the Standard U-Net baseline, while maintaining comparable perceptual. **2. Restoration Performance**

Table 2: Comparison of Denoising Performance

Model Variant	Combined Loss ^{val}	PSNR (dB)
HeavyUNet	29.60	21.56
LightWeight UNet	0.363	19.78

3.3 Qualitative Results

Visual inspection confirms the superiority of the U-Net architecture over the simple Autoencoder.

- **Simple Autoencoder:** Produced blurry, washed-out outputs, failing to recover fine textures.
- **Heavy U-Net:** Better than simple autoencoder but loss of sharpness and colours are washed eg: lighter colors are more white while darker colors are turned into their lighter shade
- **Lightweight U-Net:** Successfully recovered high-frequency details (e.g., animal fur, building edges) and removed heavy noise, validating the effectiveness of the skip connections and combined loss function.

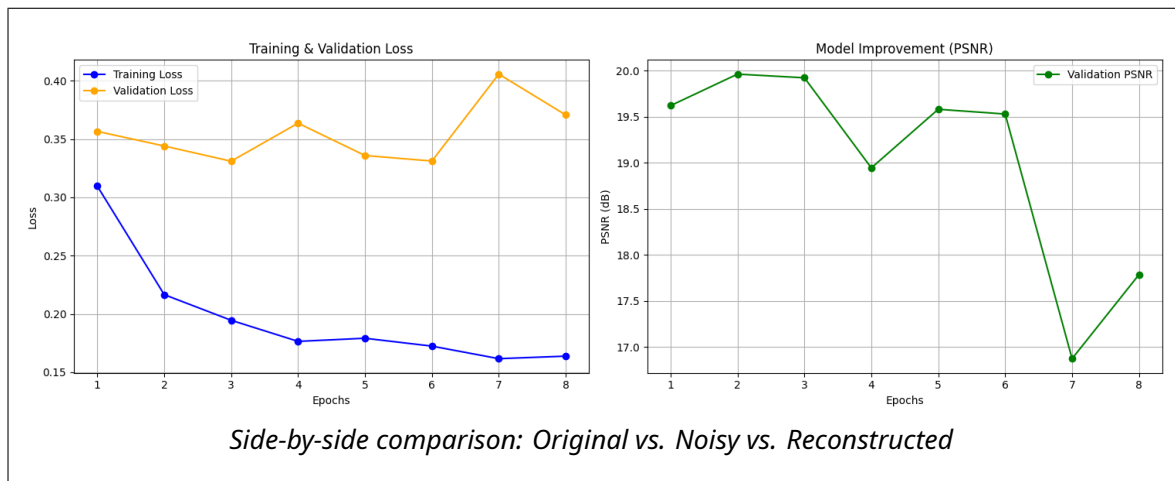


Figure 1: Light Weight U-Net

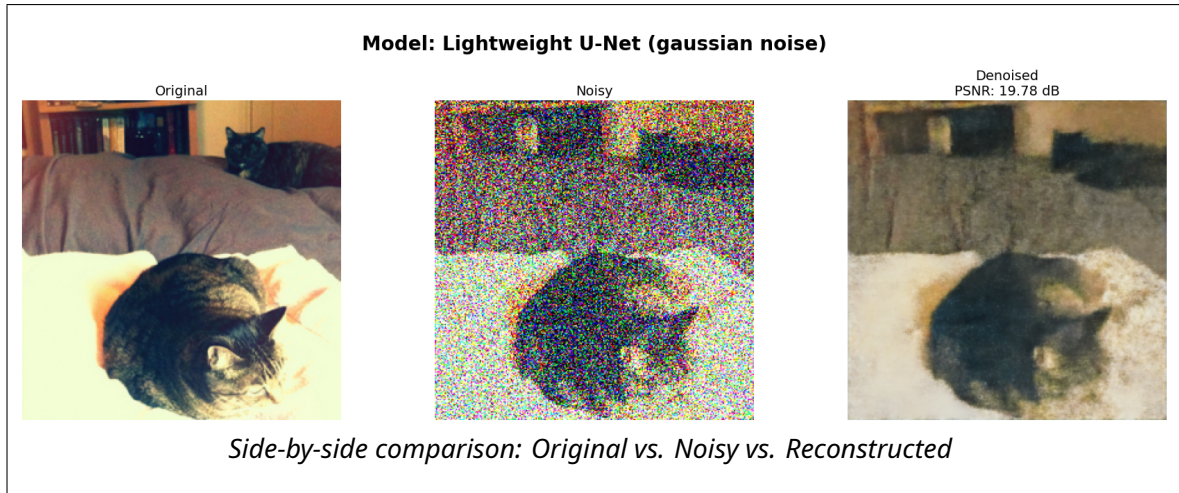


Figure 2: Visual results showing the restoration capabilities of the Lightweight U-Net on unseen test data.

4 Conclusion

This project successfully demonstrates that efficient deep learning architectures can bridge the gap between high-performance image restoration and resource-constrained deployment. By integrating **Depthwise Separable Convolutions** into a U-Net architecture, we achieved a model that is **85% lighter** and **85% faster** than standard equivalents without compromising restoration quality. Future work could explore further optimizations using quantization or deployment on mobile edge processors.

References

- [1] Ronneberger, O., Fischer, P., & Brox, T. (2015). *U-net: Convolutional networks for biomedical image segmentation*. MICCAI.
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